

Japanese Grammar Guide

Particles: (wa), (ga), (wo)

This guide covers essential Japanese grammar concepts including particles, greetings, and foundational sentence patterns.

Chapter 1: Basic Greetings

Japanese greetings change depending on the time of day and the level of formality required.

(Ohayou gozaimasu) - Good morning (formal) Used until about 10:00 AM. The casual form **(Ohayou)** is used with friends and family.

(Konnichiwa) - Hello / Good afternoon The standard daytime greeting, used from late morning through late afternoon. This is the most widely recognized Japanese greeting.

(Konbanwa) - Good evening Used after sunset and into the evening hours.

(Sayounara) - Goodbye (formal farewell) A formal farewell that implies a longer separation - you won't be seeing the person again soon. For short departures, Japanese speakers often say **(Jaa ne)** or **(Mata ne)** instead.

(Arigatou gozaimasu) - Thank you (formal) The polite form of thanks. The casual form **(Arigatou)** is used with close friends and family.

(Dou itashimashite) - You're welcome The standard reply to **(Arigatou)**.

Chapter 2: Essential Particles

Particles are small words attached to nouns, verbs, and adjectives that indicate grammatical function. They have no direct English equivalent.

(wa) - Topic Marker

The particle **(wa)** marks the **topic** of the sentence - what the sentence is about. It indicates known or previously mentioned information.

Example sentences: - **(Watashi wa gakusei desu.)** - I am a student. - **(Tanaka-sensei wa eigo no sensei desu.)** - Tanaka-sensei is an English teacher. - **(Nihongo wa muzukashii desu.)** - Japanese is difficult.

(ga) - Subject Marker

The particle **(ga)** marks the **subject** of the sentence - who or what performs the action. It emphasizes new or specific information.

Example sentences: - (Neko **ga** suki desu.) - I like cats. (emphasizing “cats” specifically) - (Dare **ga** kimashita ka?) - Who came? - (Ame **ga** futte imasu.) - It is raining.

vs

The distinction between and is one of the most challenging aspects of Japanese grammar:

(wa)	(ga)
Marks the topic (what we’re talking about)	Marks the subject (who performs the action)
Used for known or general information	Used for new, specific, or emphasized information
Can replace in many sentences	Cannot always replace

(wo) - Object Marker

The particle marks the **direct object** - the thing that receives the action of the verb.

Example sentences: - (Mizu **wo** nomimasu.) - I drink water. - (Nihongo **wo** benkyou shimasu.) - I study Japanese. - (Hon **wo** yomimasu.) - I read a book.

(ni) - Direction / Time / Location

The particle indicates direction of movement, specific time, or existence location.

Example sentences: - (Gakkou **ni** ikimasu.) - I go to school. - 7 (Shichi-ji **ni** okimasu.) - I wake up at 7 o’clock. - (Isu **ni** suwatte kudasai.) - Please sit in the chair.

(de) - Location of Action / Means

The particle indicates where an action takes place or the means by which something is done.

Example sentences: - (Toshokan **de** benkyou shimasu.) - I study at the library. - (Basu **de** gakkou ni ikimasu.) - I go to school by bus. - (Nihongo **de** hanashite kudasai.) - Please speak in Japanese.

Chapter 3: Basic Sentence Patterns

/ Polite Forms

Japanese verbs and copulas have polite (, teineigo) forms used in formal and semi-formal situations:

- **(desu)** - polite copula (is/am/are)
- **(masu)** - polite verb ending

Positive: (tabemasu) - I eat **Negative:** (tabemasen) - I don't eat **Past:** (tabemashita) - I ate **Past Negative:** (tabemasen deshita) - I didn't eat

Question Formation

Add (ka) to the end of a sentence to make it a question:

- (Gakusei desu **ka**?) - Are you a student?
 - (Nihongo wo hanashimasu **ka**?) - Do you speak Japanese?
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Practice Questions

1. What is the appropriate greeting for afternoon in Japanese?
2. When should you use instead of ?
3. What is the difference between (wa) and (ga)?
4. Translate: "I study Japanese" using the correct object marker.
5. Which particle marks the location where an action takes place?